Linnæus University
Sweden

Bachelor's Thesis

What if we stayed?

Reimagining rural futures with youth through speculative and participatory design



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Abstract

What If We Stayed? is a speculative design project exploring how young people can reimagine rural futures in Sweden. In response to rural depopulation, youth out-migration, and disengagement from community development, the project uses participatory methods to involve youth in critical conversations about place, identity, and possibility. Through interviews, workshops, and a custom-designed board game, the project investigates how speculative scenarios and creative tools can empower young people to envision alternative futures for rural living.

Grounded in social design theory and sustainability principles, the project frames the designer's role as a facilitator and co-creator, not a distant expert. The outcome, a speculative future-focused game, serves as both a conversation tool and a participatory research method. It encourages reflection, shared storytelling, and agency among youth, while offering a scalable format for use by educators, planners, and communities. This work affirms the power of design in enabling rural youth to reclaim authorship of the futures they are often excluded from shaping.

Key words

Rural Futures, Community Resilience, Speculative Design, Youth Inclusiveness, Co-Design, Gamification, Future literacy.



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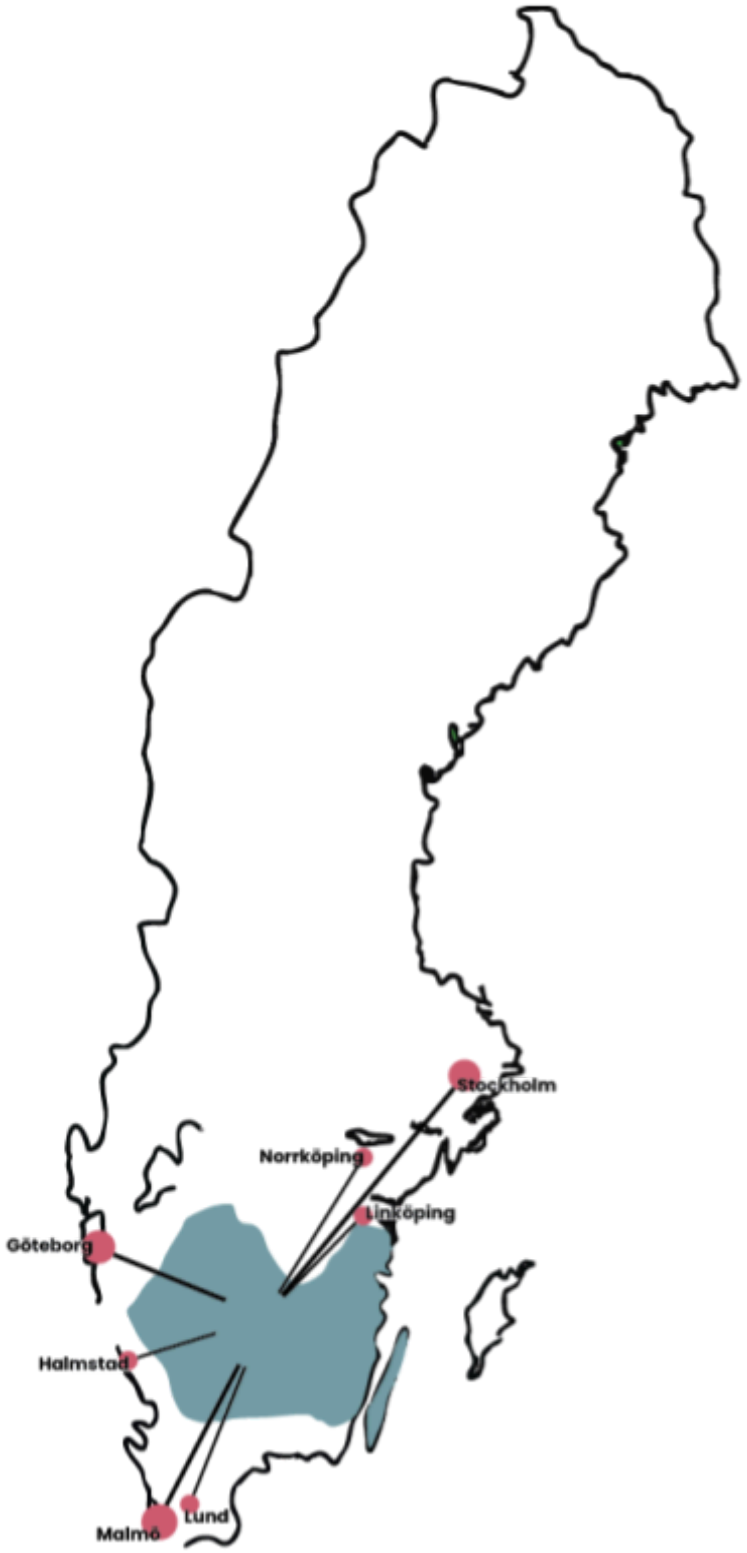


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Figure 1. Youth migration from Småland region to larger cities in Sweden. Illustration by Anda Adam (2025)



1 Key terms

To support the reader's understanding, I include a brief definition of terms that occur during this report.

Rural futures: In this project, *rural futures* refers to imagined and potential scenarios for life in rural areas. It moves beyond narratives of decline to consider how rural places might evolve through local creativity, sustainability, and youth engagement.

Speculative design: A design approach that focuses on exploring possible, probable, or preferable futures rather than solving immediate problems.

Future literacy: A concept developed by *UNESCO*. *R*efers to the ability to imagine and understand different futures.

***Gamification*:** Is the use of game elements and principles in non-game contexts to engage and motivate people.

***Participatory design*:** Is the involvement of users and stakeholders directly in the design process.

2 Introduction

2.1 Project overview & Goal

In today's world, societal structures and urbanization trends continue to draw people away from rural communities toward cities. For many young adults, urban migration is a primary life stage offering access to education, employment, and broader opportunities for personal and professional growth. Some of them choose to settle in cities long-term, but others eventually return to their rural roots, bringing back valuable experiences and skills.

Today, 56% of the world's population - 4.4 billion inhabitants - live in cities. This trend is expected to continue, with the urban population more than doubling its current size by 2050, at which point nearly 7 of 10 people will live in cities ("More Than Half the World Is Now Urban, UN Report Says" 2012).

However, rural areas face ongoing challenges: aging populations, shrinking communities, and a lack of youth engagement. Although municipalities and policymakers are actively working to make these areas more attractive and sustainable, the involvement of young people often remains very limited or overlooked.

In this context, my project *"What if we stayed? Re-imagining Rural Futures"* seeks to actively involve young people in imagining alternative futures for rural life through speculative design methods. The project aims to:

- Spark conversations around rural depopulation and urbanization trends.
- Empower young people to see themselves as an active participant in their communities.
- Explore their needs, desires, and visions for rural living.
- Highlight both the possibilities and difficulties of staying in or returning to rural communities.

- To create tools that serve as a bridge between youth and policy makers to bring together perspectives.

By using creative and collaborative tools, this project engages with young people as participants and co-designers of the rural futures they want to see.

2.2 Research questions

With that been said, I conduct my research around the following questions:

- How can speculative design methods support young people envision alternative futures for rural living?
- What role can participatory and co-creative design processes play in empowering young people as agents of change in rural communities?
- How can creative tools and speculative scenarios spark critical conversations about depopulation, urban migration, and the future of rural areas?

2.3 Context

Various initiatives, such as "*By2030* and *Future Villages* (By2030 n.d.; Future Villages n.d.), aim to revitalize rural areas by leveraging their potential and enhancing sustainability and attractiveness. Uppvidinge Municipality has also launched a project proposal, hosting "Citizen Conversations" to involve residents, entrepreneurs, and associations in shaping the region's future. One of these conversations took place in Älghult, where the community shared insights and concerns about the municipality's development.

These projects emphasize collaboration, but young people's voices and participation are often missing from the conversation. Rural communities in Sweden are known for their active associations and organizations, continuously working to improve local life through events and activities. However, these efforts are largely driven by middle-aged and senior residents, with minimal involvement from adolescents and young adults. This generational gap raises concerns about the long-term sustainability of these initiatives.

Sweden's national policy documents highlight the crucial role of young people in regional development, yet their engagement in decision-making and community planning remains limited. If projects like "By 2030" aim to attract new residents and revitalize rural areas, they must actively involve younger generations. Young people bring fresh perspectives, new ideas, and a deeper connection to the future of these communities.

Lack of Youth Engagement in Rural Swedish Communities

Despite the increasing efforts to rural revitalization in Sweden, the meaningful inclusion of young people in community development remains limited. Municipalities invest in infrastructure, sustainability programs, and community-building efforts, yet these initiatives often fail to prioritize youth as essential contributors to rural futures.

Research indicates that young adults in rural areas frequently experience a disconnection between their lived realities and local governance structures (Rosvall, Rönnlund, and Johansson 2018). Although national and EU-level policies emphasize the importance of youth participation, the implementation at municipal levels is often piecemeal or symbolic. The result is an absence of structured opportunities for young people to engage in decision-making processes affecting their communities.

Local associations and planning bodies are frequently dominated by older generations, further limiting opportunities for intergenerational collaboration and innovation.

This lack of representation feeds into a broader cycle of disengagement and out-migration. As Mulder, Lundholm, and Malmberg (2020) show, youth are less likely to return to rural hometowns if they do not feel a sense of belonging or agency in shaping their future environments. In contrast, evidence suggests that when youth are involved in local planning and development, it strengthens their community attachment and increases the likelihood of long-term investment in place (Glendinning et al. 2003).

To address this gap, more inclusive frameworks are needed, ones that not only allow youth to be heard, but that position them as co-creators of rural futures. Speculative design, as proposed by Dunne and Raby (2013), offers a compelling method. Through imaginative scenarios, storytelling, and collaborative envisioning, speculative design enables youth to articulate aspirations and challenge inherited narratives. Initiatives like the Smart Villages (SVIS) project in Sweden exemplify how such participatory and design-driven approaches can foster agency and creativity within rural development contexts.



Figure 1. Smart Villages Logo (Karlstad University). Source: Facebook @smartvillageskau. Used with credit for educational purposes.



Figure 2. Workshop from Smart Villages (Karlstad University). Source: Facebook @smartvillageskau. Used with credit for educational purposes

Perceptions of Rural Living Among Young People

Young people's perceptions of rural living in Sweden are often shaped by a combination of structural limitations and cultural narratives. Rural areas are frequently associated with limited opportunities for education, employment, and social life: factors that contribute to youth migration toward urban centers. Rosvall, Rönnlund, and Johansson (2018) argue that schools in rural contexts often reproduce narrow career expectations, reinforcing the notion that success is linked to leaving rather than staying. This sentiment is echoed in Glendinning et al. (2003), who find that while rural areas can offer a supportive upbringing, they may not fulfill young people's aspirations for autonomy and mobility.

However, rural living is not uniformly viewed as negative. For some, especially those with strong community ties or a desire for a slower pace of life, the countryside holds appeal. Mulder, Lundholm, and Malmberg (2020) highlight the significance of familial and relational networks in decisions to return to rural areas later in life. Nevertheless, these choices often emerge after a period of urban experience, suggesting that rural areas are rarely seen as viable spaces for youth-oriented futures.

Youth Participation and Agency in Rural Planning and Design

Involving young people in rural planning and design offers a range of benefits that extend beyond the immediate community. Youth bring fresh perspectives, creative problem-solving, and long-term investment potential, all of which are essential in navigating the demographic and environmental challenges facing rural areas today. Their contributions support innovation, intergenerational collaboration, and resilience, making them indispensable actors in shaping sustainable futures (Dunne and Raby 2013; Thorpe 2007).

Research shows that when young people are actively involved in community development, they are more likely to develop a sense of belonging, civic responsibility, and emotional attachment to place (Glendinning et al. 2003). These psychological and social ties are

crucial in counteracting rural out-migration and in building cohesive communities. Participatory design processes that incorporate youth voices, such as those implemented in projects like Smart Villages (SVIS) and Future Villages, demonstrate how engagement fosters both agency and innovation.

Despite this, youth perspectives are often excluded from formal planning processes. This exclusion can stem from institutional hierarchies, a lack of youth-specific engagement frameworks, or assumptions that young people lack the experience or interest to contribute meaningfully. As noted by the Swedish Agency for Youth and Civil Society (MUCF), structural barriers such as tokenism and inaccessible platforms hinder genuine youth involvement at the local level. Moreover, as Rosvall, Rönnlund, and Johansson (2018) point out, rural schools and communities often reinforce narrow social codes that discourage alternative futures or non-traditional forms of participation.

The absence of youth voices in rural planning not only perpetuates cycles of disengagement and migration but also limits the diversity of ideas in policy and design. Youth participation introduces critical insight into emerging needs, cultural shifts, and technological fluency, elements essential for adaptive, sustainable planning. Speculative design, in particular, serves as a powerful tool in this regard, enabling young people to imagine and visualize alternative realities that challenge conventional thinking (Dunne and Raby 2013).

To ensure rural development is future-oriented, inclusive, and sustainable, it is vital to embed youth agency into every stage of planning and design. Doing so not only empowers a new generation of rural residents but also strengthens the social fabric and innovative capacity of the communities they call home.

3.4 Sustainability & Change Focus

This project takes a **holistic approach to sustainability**, rooted in the belief that young people's engagement is essential to building resilient rural communities. While all **four spheres of sustainability, social, cultural, economic, and ecological**, are interwoven in this context, the project will primarily focus on the social and cultural aspects during the 10-week timeframe, with space for economic considerations to emerge throughout the process.

Social & Cultural Sustainability: At the heart of this project is the ambition to empower young people as active participants in shaping rural futures. By engaging them through co-creation and speculative design, the project seeks to:

- Strengthen their sense of ownership and belonging in rural communities.
- Challenge negative perceptions and stigmas associated with rural life.
- Encourage intergenerational collaboration to reduce the gap between older and younger residents.
- Strengthen community bonds and spark collective imagination.

As noted in RESTORE (2023), “Engaging youth in community development fosters a sense of ownership and empowerment. Young individuals develop a deeper connection to their community and its well-being when involved in decision-making.”

The project uses speculative design not just as a method, but as a transformative tool, a way for participants to imagine alternative futures and articulate their needs, values, and visions for life outside the dominant urban narrative.

Economic Sustainability: Speculating about rural futures also opens up space to envision economic possibilities, new ways of working, entrepreneurial ideas, and ways to use local resources creatively.

- Young innovators could reimagine how business, craft, or digital work could support life in smaller communities.

- There’s potential to explore ideas like circular economies, resource-sharing, or new local service models that better suit young people's needs.

Moreover, those who leave to study or work in cities can bring back new perspectives and knowledge that benefit the local economy and enrich rural development efforts.

Ecological Sustainability: While not the main focus, ecological issues are still acknowledged. The project reflects on:

- How urban migration and overpopulation in cities create ecological pressures, such as higher energy/resource consumption.
- How rural areas might contribute to sustainability by promoting self-sufficiency, low-impact lifestyles, and more balanced consumption.
- Broader environmental questions, such as how climate change contributes to out-migration in agricultural areas globally.

This speculative approach allows for critical thinking about how we live, and where we live, and what kind of future we want to co-create, especially in relation to the climate crisis.

3 Design process

From Research Questions to Design Perspective

- How can speculative design methods support young people envision alternative futures for rural living?
- What role can participatory and co-creative design processes play in empowering young people as agents of change in rural communities?
- How can creative tools and speculative scenarios spark critical conversations about depopulation, urban migration, and the future of rural areas?

These research questions emerged from a growing recognition that traditional approaches to rural development often fail to center the voices of young people, those who are most affected by decisions about the future, yet rarely invited to shape it. In order to explore youth agency, participation, and imaginative thinking around rural life, this project turns to design not just as a method of problem-solving, but as a way of problem-framing.

3.1 Speculative Design

Speculative design as a Methodological Lens

In this project, I chose to work with speculative design because it offers a unique way to open up conversations about possible, plausible, and preferable futures. Rather than predicting what will happen, speculative design helps explore what could happen, and, more importantly, what should happen. As Dunne and Raby explain in their foundational work Speculative Everything (2013), this approach shifts focus from solutions to questions. It invites participants to challenge dominant narratives, surface hidden assumptions, and imagine alternatives that may not yet exist.

This makes speculative design particularly relevant to the complex and layered challenges rural communities are facing today, such as depopulation, urban migration, climate adaptation, youth disengagement, and infrastructural decline. Through the creation of fictional scenarios, artefacts, and narratives, speculative design enables young people to reflect on their experiences and agency. It invites them to reframe rural villages not as sites of stagnation, but as spaces full of potential and imagination.

A project that significantly influenced this approach is **The Future of Aging,** developed by the **Design Futures Lab** at the University of Dundee. In this work, designers used speculative methods to explore issues related to aging in the UK, creating future artefacts and services, such as wearable healthcare devices and alternative care models. These provocations served as stimulants for conversation among older adults, caregivers, and policymakers, enabling them to express ideas, concerns, and hopes often overlooked in traditional planning.

In a similar spirit, This project seeks to use speculative design to empower young people in rural Sweden to imagine their own desirable futures, build emotional connection to place, and engage critically with the systems shaping their lives.

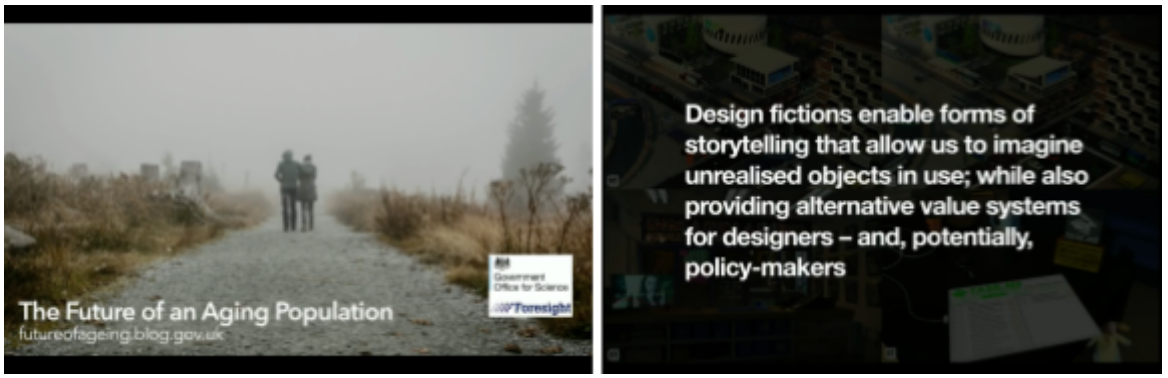


Figure 3. *Future of aging project. Source: https://futureofageing.blog.gov.uk/. Used with credit for educational purpose*

3.2 Collaborations

Collaboration has been a central part of this project, both as a method and a value. Early on, the **Future Villages** project provided a valuable contextual foundation. Their work focuses on speculative design and rural futures, and my project can be seen as a complementary continuation. I've been invited to exhibit my outcomes at their September event, where related projects will also be showcased.

Throughout the process, I've also been in dialogue with **Eva Haraldsson** from **By2030**, whose insights helped me navigate future-oriented thinking and community-based innovation. Similarly, conversations with Johan Håkansson, a planner from Uppvidinge Municipality, grounded the work in local planning realities.

A particularly fruitful peer collaboration has been with **Olivia Norderfors**, a master's student at the Swedish University of Agricultural Sciences. Her thesis explores common ground between local residents and planners in rural areas like Älghult. We exchanged insights and reflections throughout our respective processes.

The workshop participants themselves, **young adults from rural backgrounds**, were also key collaborators. Their contributions not only shaped the game's design but grounded it in lived experience. The collaborative approach aligns with participatory design theories, particularly those discussed in *The Convivial Toolbox* (Sanders and Stappers 2012), which emphasize co-creation, mutual learning, and shared authorship, core principles that have defined both the method and the spirit of this project.

3.3 Research and Interviews

My project began with an interview with colleagues Petra Lilja and Tanue Mehta, who are part of the Future Villages project, an initiative aimed at improving the sustainability attractiveness of villages in Småland. They were in the process of planning two community workshops, focusing on local engagement. However, it became apparent that their target group did not actively include younger residents. This observation prompted me to explore how youth perspectives could be brought into rural development efforts in a more meaningful way.

Field Study

Visit to Älghult

As part of the field research, I went on an observational visit to the village of Älghult, one of the communities involved in the Future Villages initiative. Upon observation was the absence of dedicated spaces for young people to meet or socialize. This was reinforced during informal conversations with residents, who mentioned that local teens had, at times, broken into abandoned buildings, suggesting a lack of safe and inclusive environments for youth. These insights highlighted a gap in the existing development approach and informed my decision to focus more closely on the needs and perspectives of young people in rural areas.

Interviews with Young Adults

To build on these observations, I conducted a series of interviews with peers who have direct experience with rural life in the Smålands region and to keep confidentiality I will not mention full names.

- Tristan, a 20-year-old student from a small village in Kalmar municipality, shared his thoughts on rural life, including its challenges and what might encourage young adults like him to

return after their studies. He emphasized the decline of rural populations as a major concern, communities shrinking and services disappearing made it hard to imagine a future there, despite his interest.

- Alexandra, a student who commutes from a village 65 km from Växjö, spoke about her values: proximity to nature, community connection, and opportunities for hands-on living like agriculture. Her partner, a part-time remote graphic designer, joined via Zoom and shared his challenges, namely the unreliable internet connectivity, which limited his ability to work full-time remotely. They both expressed a desire to remain in rural areas but acknowledged the limitations: job availability, infrastructure, and connectivity being key among them.

These interviews revealed recurring themes: young people are not necessarily disinterested in rural living, but they are often pushed away by structural challenges, limited employment options, poor infrastructure, and a sense of social or cultural isolation. These insights became central to how I shaped the goals of my project and informed the design choices I made moving forward.

3.4 Social Design

Sustainability, and the Role of the Designer

Building on the speculative design approach, this project also draws from **Ezio Manzini's** work on **design for social innovation and community collaboration**. Manzini advocates for a shift in design practice, from creating finished products to cultivating systems of relationships, care, and participation. In his vision, designers act not as distant experts, but as enablers who support local capacities, foster dialogue, and help communities co-design their own futures. This resonates deeply with the goals of this project, which focuses not on rural decline as a problem to be solved from the outside, but as a context rich with unused potential for **social innovation** (Manzini 2015).

Manzini's approach highlights how small, local actions, what he calls "**diffuse design**", can lead to meaningful, sustainable change. This aligns with the **four spheres of sustainability** often referenced in **meta-design theory:** personal, social, ecological, and economic. Together, these spheres remind us that sustainable futures are not only about environmental performance, but also about cultivating meaningful lives, social cohesion, and locally resilient economies. This multi-dimensional view of sustainability is particularly relevant for rural areas, where community vitality and ecological balance are deeply intertwined.

3.5 Positioning

As a designer, I position myself within this framework as a **facilitator, listener, and co-creator**. This project is not about proposing a "perfect" vision of the rural future from a distance, it is about opening up space for young people to explore their own questions, desires, and challenges together. My role is to hold that space: to design tools and experiences that invite critical reflection, collaboration, and imagination.

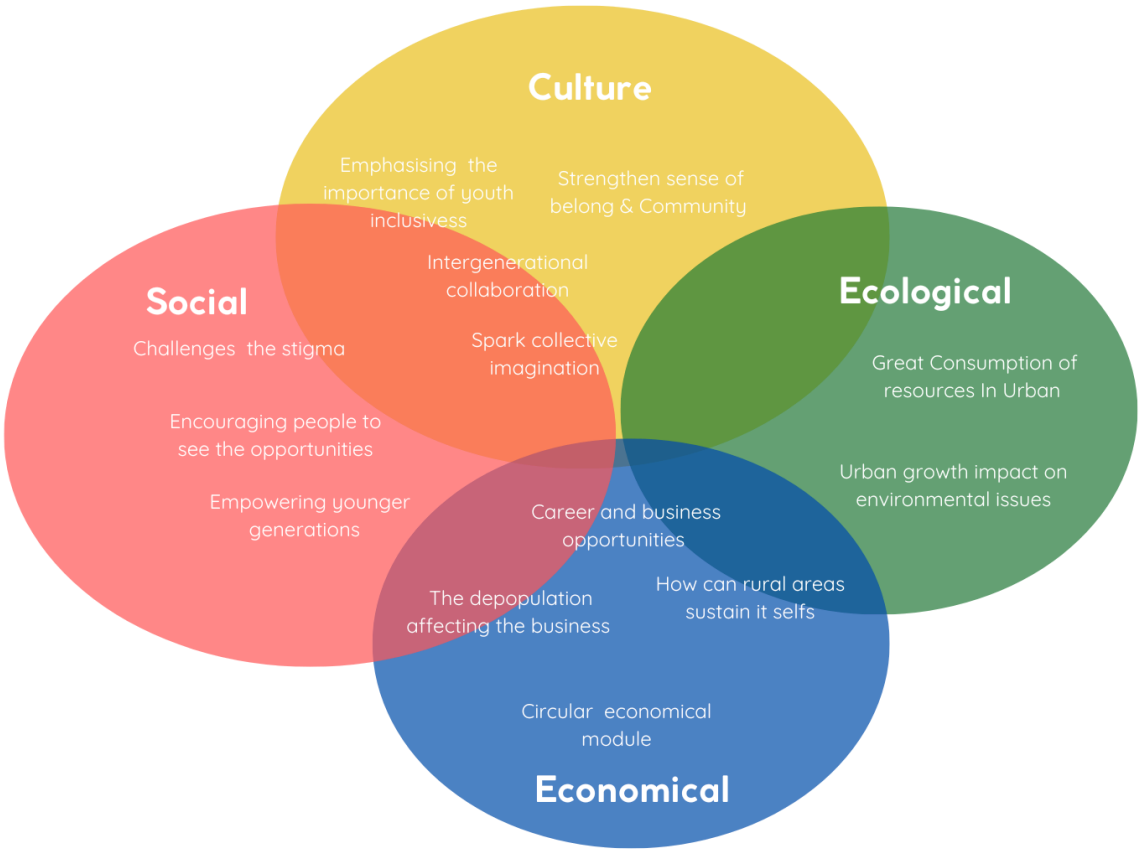


Figure 4. Relation to sustainability - illustration by Anda Adam (2025)

I also approach this work not only as a designer, but as a young person living in Sweden, personally navigating the same uncertainties and worries about the future that rural youth face: Where will I live after I'm done with my studies? What kind of future feels possible? What does a good life look like outside the city? This lived perspective shapes the way I approach the design process, not from the outside looking in, but from within the very ecosystem I'm exploring.

Through **participatory and speculative design methods**, I aim to make young people active agents in imagining new futures for rural life, not simply for the sake of academic inquiry, but as an act of reclaiming agency, place, and possibility. The **workshop format** is central here: it is not just a method, but an unfolding, co-created part of the design itself. The process is the project, an evolving space of dialogue, making, and shared visioning.

3.6 Participatory Workshop

To involve the intended audience in the design process, I conducted a participatory workshop with a group of young adults who have a personal connection to rural life, I had 4 participants in the age group (21-30). All participants either grew up in rural areas or currently live in villages. Since the project focuses on rural development through the lens of youth engagement, it was essential to include their perspectives early in the process.



Figure 5. Workshop mindmapping and game prototype testing

Workshop Goal

The main goal was to engage young people in imagining and co-creating speculative future scenarios for rural life, highlighting their needs, challenges, and aspirations. The session used speculative design methods to spark dialogue and imagination, helping participants think beyond current limitations.

The decision to use a generative workshop format was also informed by methods outlined in **The Convivial Toolbox** (Sanders and Stappers 2012), which emphasizes creative collaboration in the early, exploratory stages of design. These methods are particularly effective in surfacing unspoken needs, latent desires, and tacit knowledge, elements often overlooked in conventional research. The speculative board game used in the session served as a conversational stimulant , helping participants articulate complex feelings about place, identity, and possible futures in a playful but thoughtful way.

This approach was further inspired by the **Rural Future project**,an organizational collaboration between Cadland Estate, and Southern Policy Centre in the UK, it aims to explore the future of rural communities in the South of England, focusing on evolving challenges, opportunities, and sustainability.The project demonstrates how rural communities can become active participants in shaping future-oriented strategies through locally grounded design interventions. Their work highlights how imaginative, participatory processes can foster a stronger sense of agency and belonging in rural areas.



Figure 6. Rural Future project Source: Web page https://rural-future.net/. Used with credit for educational purposes

Workshop Structure

The workshop began with a short introduction to the project and a name round to establish a sense of familiarity among the participants. This was followed by a reflection session designed to ground the conversation in participants' real-life experiences. They were asked to reflect and write down their responses to the following prompts:

- What I value in village life
- Challenges I've faced or observed
- Things I wish existed
- Why I would stay (or move there)

We then discussed these reflections as a group. The session generated an open and honest conversation, revealing both shared values and diverse lived experiences. This warm-up was effective in establishing trust and opening up space for more speculative thinking in the next part of the workshop.

Reflections and Analysis

This reflective session not only helped participants articulate their personal connections to rural life, but also provided rich insight into the emotional and practical dimensions of rural living. The values and needs that emerged from the discussion closely align with the "Human Needs Framework" outlined in *The Designer's Atlas of Sustainability* (Thorpe 2007, 115), particularly in relation to social belonging, identity, and subsistence.

3.7 Gamification as a Tool

The second part of the workshop focused on testing a prototype board game I developed as a tool to explore future village scenarios. The goal was to see what worked, what didn't, and how the game could be improved.

Participants were divided into teams and introduced to a simple game board featuring five thematic zones: housing, nature, services, community, and mobility. A dice determined where each team landed on the board. Depending on the space, players drew different types of cards and responded accordingly:

- **Speculative prompts** (Future Twists): Participants received a future scenario related to the zone, delivered by me as the game narrator. They then wrote how they would respond to the challenge.
- **Needs & Dreams cards:** Players described something they would like to see in that specific zone, e.g., a co-working space in the "services" zone.
- **Action cards:** These asked participants to propose interventions, policies, or changes they would implement to improve life in their imagined village.

The game was designed to stimulate speculative thinking and act as a conversation starter, and in that regard, it was successful. The gameplay sparked rich dialogue, playful imagination, and unexpected ideas. It also generated valuable feedback on how to make the experience more intuitive.

From this feedback, I made several key changes:

- Created a clearer instruction manual
- Redesigned the layout of the game board
- Added a new card type called"Did you know" aka Facts card, encouraging players to share interesting or quirky facts about their own rural communities, which also helped balance the tone of the game

- Introduced a "Future Diary" or notebook component to support reflection and documentation something that will be part of the final kit

The overall concept “Vår by” was designed as a low-barrier, high-imagination way to involve young people in thinking creatively about rural development. By placing them in active roles as “future-makers,” the game aimed to encourage ownership, agency, and visioning beyond current constraints.







Figure 7. Pictures of testing the final prototype

Why Gamification?

I chose gamification, as a creative method and also as a strategic one. Research shows that gamified tools can significantly enhance engagement in social initiatives. They tap into intrinsic motivators like curiosity, achievement, and collaboration, which are especially effective in participatory settings.

Gamification fosters:

- Higher engagement through interactive formats
- Motivation and sustained participation
- Constructive behavior change via feedback and goal setting
- Data collection that can help refine and evaluate processes
- Broader inclusion, attracting participants who might not respond to traditional formats
- Community-building through collaborative play and discussion

In the context of my project, these benefits aligned well with the aim of engaging youth in speculative thinking around rural futures. The game served as both a playful entry point and a structured tool for ideation and reflection. "*Gamification in Social Impact.*" Smartico Blog.

3.8 Future Literacy in the Design Process

To support participants in thinking beyond present constraints and engaging more deeply with the future, I incorporated **future literacy principles** into the game design, specifically within the **speculative prompt cards** (called Future Prompts). These cards were designed to introduce participants to future scenarios that challenge assumptions and expand their imagination.

Future literacy, as defined by UNESCO, is the ability to understand the role of the future in what we see and do in the present. It

involves recognizing that the future is not predetermined, but rather something we can influence through our choices today. Future literacy encourages people to question dominant narratives and explore alternative possibilities, making it particularly relevant to projects that aim to co-create long-term social and environmental change.

In the context of my project, future literacy enabled young people with rural connections to reframe challenges as opportunities and imagine futures where rural life is not just preserved but reimagined. Using this framework, I generated the content of the Future Prompts card deck, crafting prompts that invite speculation around key areas of rural life.

Each card corresponds to one of the zones on the game board and presents a scenario that pushes participants to consider emerging challenges or transformative shifts:

Zone: Nature & Land Use
Themes: land management, biodiversity, agriculture, climate resilience.

Zone: Community & Belonging
Themes: aging populations, youth migration, inclusion, identity.

Zone: Services & Infrastructure
(Removed in the final version but used in the prototype)
Themes: digital divide, centralization, access to essential services.

Zone: Mobility & Access
Themes: isolation, fuel dependency, sustainable transport, intergenerational accessibility.

Zone: Work & Economy *(New zone added in final version)*
Themes: rural employment, digital work, local economies, cooperative models.



Figure 8. Board elements

the **revised game structure** now includes the following card categories:

- **Future Prompt Cards**: Speculative "what if?" scenarios based on Future Literacy principles. These create the core imaginative challenge of the game.
- **Needs & Dreams Cards**: Invite participants to share personal or collective visions, highlighting what's missing, what they long for, or what would make rural life more meaningful.



Figure 9. Cards deck

- **Action Cards**: Encourage players to propose interventions, new ideas, changes, or policies. These can be practical, experimental, or even utopian, covering shifts in infrastructure, governance, technology, or culture.
- **"Did You Know?" AKA Facts Cards**: Offer playful or surprising facts about rural life. These can be pre-written or shared by participants as a way to lighten the mood or anchor abstract discussions in real-world anecdotes.

Why Future Literacy?

Incorporating Future Literacy allowed me to design a more **open-ended, inclusive, and agency-driven experience** for participants. Rather than viewing rural youth as passive observers of change, the game positions them as **co-authors of possible futures**, a perspective that is often missing from rural development discussions. By imagining alternative

futures, players can reflect on their current realities and begin to articulate what kinds of changes they want to see.

3.9 Ethical considerations

One of the main ethical concerns I encountered in this project was the question of working with underage participants. Since the target group included youth in rural areas, many of whom might be under 18, this raised important issues related to informed consent, privacy, and power dynamics. So rather than directly involving minors in interviews or research activities, I chose to adapt my methodology so the project remained ethically responsible. I did this in two key ways:

- Working with young adults: I conducted interviews and workshops with participants who were 18 or older, but who had personal experiences growing up in rural areas. Their insights offered valuable perspectives on rural youth experiences while avoiding the ethical risks associated with engaging minors in research.

- Designing an inclusive tool: I developed a speculative board game that is suitable for all ages, making it possible for the tool to be used beyond the research context. Although my primary research did not involve minors, the game itself can be used with younger participants, not necessarily as research subjects, but as part of a wider process of community dialogue. This makes the tool adaptable for use by educators, policymakers, families, or local organizations who wish to engage children and youth in conversations about the future of rural life.

In this way, the ethical limitations of involving minors directly not only shaped my research methods, but also influenced the design of the final outcome. By creating a flexible and age-inclusive format, I ensured that the project could have longer-term and wider relevance, while maintaining clear ethical boundaries during the design process.

4 Conclusion

This project set out to explore what role participatory and co-creative design processes can play in empowering young people as agents of change in rural communities. The results suggest that these methods hold significant potential, when they are accessible, imaginative, and grounded in participants' lived experiences.

Through speculative prompts, co-created discussions, and a game-based format, young people engaged deeply and meaningfully with questions about the future of rural life. The workshop and board game did not seek to provide fixed answers, but rather opened a space for participants to express their needs, reflect on their values, and propose bold or unexpected ideas. This process fostered a sense of agency and revealed how much untapped insight and care exists among rural youth.

At the same time, the project also highlighted certain limitations. While the participatory methods sparked dialogue, turning those conversations into lasting structural influence would require deeper partnerships with institutions or local governance. Additionally, involving underage youth directly raised ethical questions, which I addressed by designing the game to be a flexible tool usable by families, educators, or communities, beyond the scope of this thesis.

Ultimately, this work contributes to change-making not by delivering a solution, but by proposing a method, a way to think with and through the future. It affirms that young people's voices are essential in imagining rural futures, and that design has the power to make those voices not only heard, but acted upon.

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6 Appendix



Game Installation

Game Guidebook

vår by

A game for story telling, dreaming and imagining better futures together.

About:

"Vår by": is a speculative future-focused game, serves as both a **conversation tool and a participatory research method.** It encourages reflection, shared storytelling, and agency among youth, while offering a scalable format for use by educators, planners, and communities.



The Core Pieces

1 Puzzle-Board Map – Pieces that come together to form your village space
1 Central Arrow Spinner – Points to a deck or a zone for your next prompt

Game Elements

The Card Decks
(Color-Coded)

1. Future Prompts Deck
Imagine big "what ifs" and possible futures. Each card corresponds to one of the zones on the game board and presents a scenario that pushes participants to consider emerging challenges.

2. Did You Know? Deck
Real facts, stories, and wisdom from the village (with blanks to add your own!)

3. Needs & Dreams Deck
Express your hopes, longings, and creative ideas for the village. (with blanks to add your own!)

4. Action Deck
Practical and imaginative things we can do to make change happen (with blanks to add your own!)



1. Set-Up

- Assemble the puzzle board in the center of your play area. It could symbolize the village map, zones of life, or seasons of the year.
- Shuffle and set out the four card decks around the board:
Future Prompts, Did You Know, Needs & Dreams, & Action cards.

- Remember to Prepare **The Extra Blank cards & a pen or pencil**

How to Play?

2. Start Your Turn
- On your turn:
Spin or rotate the arrow.
Wherever the arrow points, choose a card from that deck.
Read it out loud and respond!
Other players may join in.
Then pass the turn clockwise.

3. Optional Twist: Use Zones!

After drawing a card, you can relate your answer to that zone.
"What would this look like in the zone I landed on?"

4. After the Game
Use your Future Diary Draw something from your turn
Write a memory, wish, or invention
Collect stories from others
What do you wish for your village?

